



Commentary

Why Consumers Say One Thing and Do Another (and Why That's Not the Real Problem)

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Ask consumers what they plan to buy, how they will behave, or which brands they prefer, and you will almost always get a confident answer. Watch what actually happens in market, and the story often looks very different. And we are not even touching on the frequency of purchase.

This disconnect, commonly labelled the “say–do gap”, has become one of the most debated challenges in FMCG. It is frequently cited as proof that consumer research is unreliable, that stated intent can’t be trusted, or that traditional insights are no longer fit for purpose.

But that conclusion misses the point.

The **say–do gap** is not a flaw in consumers. It is a signal about how decisions are really made and about how data needs to be designed, interpreted, and connected to reality.

The myth of the “honest consumer”

Consumers are not lying when they tell us what they intend to do. In fact, most are answering honestly, based on the information, emotions, and context available to them at that moment.

The problem is that real-world purchasing rarely happens at that same moment, or under those same conditions.

Price changes. Promotions intervene. Availability shifts. Habits override intentions. Social context matters. Cognitive shortcuts take over. What felt certain in a survey becomes negotiable at the moment of truth.

The gap emerges not because consumers are unreliable, but because **human decision-making is situational**. Asking people what they will do captures one layer of truth. Observing what they actually do captures another. Neither is wrong, but neither is sufficient on its own.

Why more data doesn't automatically mean better decisions

In response to the say–do gap, many organizations have doubled down on collecting more data: more surveys, more signals, more AI, more dashboards. Yet in many cases, decision confidence hasn't improved, only complexity has. According to [NIQ's CMO Outlook Report](#), **54% of CMOs say they are having difficulty connecting the data across different sources** – a fascinating 23% increase vs year prior.

That's because the issue isn't volume of data. It's **how data connects to outcomes**.

When intent data lives in isolation from behavioral data, it can easily mislead. When behavioral data lacks context, it explains what happened but not why. And when analytics systems don't learn from real-world results, the same biases repeat cycle after cycle.

Bridging the say–do gap requires a different mindset: not choosing between what people say and what they do, but **designing systems that continuously learn from both**.

From snapshots to learning systems

This is where closed-loop data systems matter, but not in the way the term is often used.

A true closed-loop system is not about automation for its own sake, or about pushing insights faster into activation. It is about **building feedback mechanisms that improve prediction over time**.

In practice, this means linking stated consumer responses to what happens next in market and using that learning to recalibrate future decisions. Overstatement is corrected. Execution effects are accounted for. Models evolve as categories, channels, and behaviors change.

Instead of treating each launch, campaign, or innovation as a one-off bet, closed-loop systems turn them into inputs for smarter future choices. The result is not perfect foresight but **progressively more accurate foresight**.

Why the Say–Do Gap Is Growing, Not Shrinking

The FMCG environment has rarely been more volatile. Inflation, premiumization trade-offs, private label pressure, health and sustainability tensions, and rapid channel shifts have fundamentally changed how consumers prioritize and choose.

In this context, relying on static assumptions or on intent data without behavioral grounding is risky. But dismissing consumer voice altogether is equally dangerous.

What’s needed is the ability to **model through uncertainty**: to understand where intent is likely to hold, where it is likely to break, and why.

That capability doesn’t come from a single dataset or methodology. It comes from **integrated systems that respect the complexity of human behavior while remaining anchored in reality, that is actual behavioral data**.

Reframing the say–do gap

The say–do gap is often framed as a problem to be eliminated. In reality, it is a source of insight.

It tells us where consumers feel tension. Where aspiration collides with constraint. Where brands win by making choices easier—or lose by misreading what matters in the moment of truth.

Organizations that learn to work with this gap, rather than ignore or oversimplify it, are better equipped to design innovations, set pricing, allocate investment, and activate brands with confidence.

The future of FMCG decision-making doesn’t belong to those with the most data. It belongs to those who can **connect what people say, what they do, and what happens to drive growth—again and again**.

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